

At the Edge of the Hole: Spring Night

By Je Yun Moon

The Hole

*What kind of hole devours babies, then spits out their bones?*¹

The poet cries out. In *Spring Night* by Kim Eon Hee, this question condenses into a figure of a dead dog, beaten, exhausted, longing only for the violence to end, for sleep to come.

From bare magnolia branches

Fist-sized

Skulls

*Burst forth, tearing through April's air*²

In this poetic image, magnolia and skeleton become indistinguishable. It is this hole that devours babies and spits out their bones as blossom. This is not purification nor erasure, but violent passage—the body broken down and propelled outward again in another form. What emerges is not restoration but transformation, where violence and renewal converge, where bone and blossom, death and afterlife, remain entangled. It is through this process that the dead body becomes a hole that devours itself: an opening through which the living are compelled to confront a rupture that cannot be resolved, only sustained.

The dead body has long been a central concern in Cha Yeonsa's practice. In their earlier work, Cha created one-dimensional paper-cut collages from forensic photographs of criminal victims, using Dak paper (handmade mulberry paper, known as *banji*) left behind by their late father—an act of offering, as they describe it, the body of their late father to comfort the dead. The starting point was the bodies encountered in forensic books, and the corpses that visited through sleep paralysis. Over time, a ritualistic dimension was added, and the collage expanded into performance. Turning to Buddhist practices, Cha began performing acts of mourning and consolation for those they had never known in life. This practice unfolded alongside a series of collective losses that marked their generation that came to coincide within the same temporal horizon. Cha was exactly the same age as the students of Danwon High School at the time of the Sewol ferry disaster, and shared the generational proximity to many of the victims of the Itaewon Halloween crowd crush.

The performance *Spring Night* began from Cha's desire to be with the dead dog she encountered in Kim Eon Hee's poem of the same title. Presented at the Doosan Art Center in the winter of 2025 in Seoul, the performance took as its material fifteen dakjonggi panels laid directly on the floor of the gallery. Eight panels carried the image of the dead dog from the poem; six, the image of a cat Cha had witnessed on a shoreline, trapped and deliberately placed near the water's edge; one, the image of a dead

child encountered in a forensic book—the cause of death unknown—whom Cha names the “Christ Child.” Outlined and collaged in white mulberry paper, these reliefs were not symbols. They were holes—openings through which the living confronts the dead body. To face this hole—to carry it, to tend to it, or simply to refuse to turn away—marks the threshold from which Cha's performance *Spring Night* unfolds. Borrowing from Jacques Lacan, and following Hal Foster's reading, this hole is the Real: what emerges at the point where the symbolic order can no longer hold.³ It is a structural tear, a gap through which what resists symbolization makes itself felt and as a rupture in the world of the living.

The performance begins with a modest invitation: a call for volunteers to clear the floor. I found myself holding one of these panels. The audience was invited to lift the panels and carry them outside—as a gesture responding to the dead dog's wish for sleep. This simple act of holding the panels opened an affective terrain that precedes language, where perception, obligation, mourning, and survival remain entangled. We carried the panels to the window gallery, where Tetokun, the artist's dog, living with impaired hearing and sight, lay asleep, and placed the images beside him. The dead were brought into proximity with the living dog: not to restore what had been lost, but to hold it in relation, to offer a rest that had been denied. This act did not resolve the violence embedded in the image. Instead, the gestures of lifting, carrying, and placing became a form of care—a way of remaining with what cannot be undone, of sustaining a relation to the dead without closure.

This essay begins from contemplating the hole that the dead body puts us in contact with. The dead body never appears smoothly. Its smell, its rotting flesh, the movement of maggots, the deformation of body parts through decay—these threaten our own body-image. In encountering the dead body, we are made aware of the precariousness of the boundary that separates us from what we expel: as the hole devours flesh, representation begins to fail. At this threshold, Julia Kristeva's notion of the abject gives this encounter a visceral, embodied dimension. The abject is what the subject expels in order to constitute itself, yet can never fully exclude. It is experienced as a disturbance—an affective and sensory wavering in which the borders between self and other, inside and outside, life and death begin to lose their hold. The dead body is its most paradigmatic figure. Here, I read the Real and the abject together: the Real as that which escapes symbolization, and the abject as the lived, sensory form of that encounter—the smell, the texture, the visual confrontation with decay that no concept fully absorbs.

The dead dog's body, reincarnated as magnolia branches in Kim's poem, is not only abject but becomes, in Kristeva's terms, a site of defilement. Defilement is one of the forms through which the abject is historically and culturally coded: where the experience of boundary collapse is given a name, a ritual logic, and a demand for response. It is not simply dirtiness to be removed, but a condition that calls for the structuring of one's relation to what threatens. For Kristeva, this structuring does not eliminate the threatening substance; it organizes a way of remaining in its

1. Kim Eon Hee, *Spring Night in Horangmalko* (Seoul: Moonji Publishing, 2024), trans. Soje (2025).
2. Ibid.

3. Hal Foster, *The Return of the Real: The Avant-Garde at the End of the Century* (Cambridge, MA: MIT Press, 1996), p. 132. Jacques Lacan, *The Four Fundamental Concepts of Psycho-Analysis [Seminar XII]*, trans. Alan Sheridan (London: Penguin, 1979), p. 55.

proximity without being undone by it.⁴ Cha's performance *Spring Night* works precisely within this logic. The gestures of lifting, carrying, and placing do not resolve or purify the image of the dead dog. Instead, they create a minimal ritual structure—one that allows participants to hold, move, and set down what defiles, sustaining a relation to the wound without closure. These are not symbolic resolutions, but small, deliberate acts that make it possible to remain, however briefly, at the edge of the hole.

An Affective Terrain

Before the Prui game begins, Cha tells a story. She could not invite friends to her house because it was too dirty.⁵ Someone told her: just let them come, and clean it together when they arrive. The fifteen panels on the floor—the dead dog, the salt cat, the Christ Child—were the “dirty house”. And we had already cleaned it. The act of lifting, carrying, and placing the panels beside Tetokun was not only a gesture of mourning; it was the preparation of a space. The defilement had been held, moved, and set down. The house was ready. It is into this cleared terrain that the Prui game opens.

The Prui game begins in darkness. We are asked to close our eyelids and walk slowly. In this darkness, the hole does not disappear; it becomes tactile. The hand you reach for might be a stranger's. You ask: Prui? They ask back: Prui? Neither of you is Prui yet. You let go and keep walking. I did not expect to feel responsible. But with my eyes closed, moving through a space I could not see, I became aware of the bodies around me—their proximity, their vulnerability. Someone ahead of me did not know I was there. I slowed down. What emerges in this darkness is not representation but a redistribution of attentiveness: a reorientation of the body toward what it cannot see.

This game further explores the boundaries of the self and the other through the spreading “infection” of becoming Prui. Once a participant is designated as Prui, they no longer release the hands they find; instead, they hold on, forming a growing, silent cluster of bodies. At some point, someone does not let go. They hold your hand in silence. You have found Prui, or Prui has found you. You stop asking and begin to accumulate—hands joined in the dark, a growing cluster of bodies that does not know its own shape. The chain extends without anyone seeing it whole. This is not a resolution of the hole. The panels have been carried out, but what they held remains. The game does not purify the space; it reorganizes the bodies within it.

What the Prui game produces is not transcendence but proximity—a temporary structure in which the isolated body finds itself held, without knowing by whom. When the lights return, the silence that follows is not empty. It carries the residue of what has just passed between bodies—the tentative reach, the held hand, the question asked into darkness and left

unanswered. The hole is still there. But for a moment, we were at its edge together. Within this affective terrain, the artist's “dirty house” is no longer a source of private shame. Instead, through the touch of “guests” and the shared darkness of the game, the performance space is reconstructed into a site where bodies—both living and dead—can finally coexist in a state of mutual support and visibility.

After Words

What follows the Prui game is a sequence of poetic enactments carried by two performers. If the earlier sections displaced the image and redistributed touch, this final movement turns to language as artistic material: cited, cut, and made to circulate. Cha described this section as the outcome of an extended immersion in the poetic world of Kim Eon Hee. Since 2022, Cha has been working with Kim's poetry as compositional material, beginning with the performance *Mosquitolarvajui* (December 2022), where Kim's poetry first entered the work. This performance begins with a scene drawn from Kim's *Another Day, Another Morning*, staging a collective awakening of those who had died: “women” expansively conceived to encompass multiple genders, even exceeding the limits of the category itself.⁶ What developed over time was not a method of quotation but of collage: reading through the entirety of Kim's work, extracting poetic fragments, and reassembling them into a new terrain of affect. The result is a script composed from twenty-nine poems by Kim Eon Hee, centered on *Those Cats!*, alongside nine poems by Sylvia Plath, anchored by *Lady Lazarus*. From this arrangement emerge twenty-four scenes whose organization already registers a persistent return to death and survival.

For Cha, the poetic body of Kim's work operates like a “Frankenstein”: its parts severed and recombined beyond their initial order; An arm becomes a foot; a mouth becomes an anus.⁷ The original poetic fragment enters a new relational field. In this structural logic of the collage, language begins to designify: to circulate as “surplus utterance”, producing not meaning but force.⁸ The original contexts—historical, biographical, political—are neither erased nor preserved; they are transmuted. What remains is a condition in which poetic language moves across bodies, attaching and detaching, producing temporary alignments.

Cha's script presses against Bae Sunhee's body—exposing, unhinging, and eroticizing as it draws her into the world of Kim's poetry. What draws Cha is that Bae never fully cohered as “a woman” to begin with; something like “they,” or even “it,” has always leaked through her performance. In this work, that leakage is not corrected but pursued, as the “femaleness” in Kim's *Those Cats!* fractures and branches across Bae's body, refusing to settle into a singular form. Cha explains this mode of working as queering in its orientation: the performance is not about expressing a self but about registering a failure of the given identity—a body that cannot

4. Julia Kristeva, *Powers of Horror: An Essay on Abjection*, trans. Leon S. Roudiez (New York: Columbia University Press, 1982), chap. 3, “Defilement as Ritual.” The distinction I draw here between abject as experience and defilement as its ritual codification is my own reading, developed from Kristeva's argument rather than explicitly drawn by her.
5. The artist's engagement with the “Pru” game is informed by Bernard De Koven's *The Infinite Playground* (Cambridge, MA: MIT Press, 2020).

6. Kim Eon Hee, *Another Day, Another Morning* (Hyundae Munhak, July 2019). From 2023, as Cha began developing the Festival works, this engagement became more sustained: the phrase “this unbelievable sleep” from *Another Day, Another Morning* resurfaced as the title of their online solo exhibition.
7. Cha Yeonsá explained, excerpted from the conversation between the artist, April 26, 2026.
8. Ibid.

hold its assigned form.⁹

What Cha sought in Bae Sunhee was not representation but exposure: the affect-energy of Kim's language moving through the performer's body until something breaks open. Kim's sentences become vectors of pressure. The performer does not deliver the text; she is seized by it—brought to the threshold already marked earlier as the hole, the point at which representation fails and the distinction between inside and outside begins to loosen. Within this terrain, the body becomes the site at which these displacements are registered. In Bae's part, the threshold is materialized through the act of urination. What is expelled is neither staged as spectacle nor absorbed into narrative meaning; it interrupts. The body no longer holds its boundaries. What should remain contained crosses into the shared space, rendering the instability that the earlier image of the corpse had already announced. At this moment, the hole is no longer metaphorical. It is enacted as a passage, an opening through which the body exceeds itself.

Plath's *Lady Lazarus* enters through Nari Sohn—Plath scholar and the artist's mother. This doubling is not incidental. The poem arrives already carrying a relational weight: Cha has described *Lady Lazarus* as the medium through which she worked through her own relationship with her mother, and through which she wanted to keep Nari Sohn "alive".¹⁰ In Cha's reading, the poem is not primarily an elegy but an assertion of the will to survive. Death here is not a terminal event but a rehearsal—something performed again and again, nine times, each time a comeback rather than an ending.

*I am only thirty.
And like the cat I have nine times to die.*¹¹

Cha has noted the particular theatricality of Plath's language: its meaning shifts depending on what precedes it, who speaks it, and the context it enters. Plath's invocation of the Holocaust—a suffering she did not live—is not appropriation but a mode of becoming-other, of inhabiting what one cannot claim. This is the condition of citation itself: language that has already detached from its original body and been reassigned. What Cha does with Plath is a form of overwriting.

Nari Sohn's enactment of Plath runs alongside Kim's rather than merging with it. The two structures remain in tension, their proximity generating a field in which language accumulates without stabilizing. What the convergence produces is not synthesis but friction: two obsessions with death held in proximity, each intensifying the other. The structure of repetition—Plath's I have done it again, Kim's *Those Cats!* returning as a refrain—strips death of its status as an event and reframes it as something practiced, survived, and practiced again. The body, in both poets, is treated not as a solid entity but as a site of dispersal: Plath's full set of teeth, her eye pits, unwrapped before a peanut-crunching crowd; Kim's cats flinging fur and viscera as they run. For both, dispersal is a mode of being rather than destruction.

The ritualistic conclusion by Ven. Donghwan serves as the final gathering of these scattered fragments—the linguistic residues, the bodily discharges, and the abjected identities—into a field of transition. If the earlier sections of the performance were dedicated to the "undoing" of the subject and the opening of the "hole," this closing ritual does not seek to seal that rupture, but to sanctify it.

As the monk performs the *Heonjwage* and *Jinryeongge*, the space is no longer a site of trauma, but a hallowed ground where the "wandering spirits" and the "unresolved presences" are invited to coexist. *Heonjwage* and *Jinryeongge* are traditional Buddhist ritual chants used to hallow a space and invite the spirits of the deceased. In this performance, they serve to bridge the sacred and the abject, offering a "seat" of rest for unresolved presences while marking the transition from ritualized mourning to a final release of the space. The heavy resonance of the chants provides a container for the friction between Plath's and Kim's language, transforming the force of their words into a collective invocation. What follows is a synchronized exit: Ven. Donghwan and the artist's friend and a queer performer Isu Mignon Mignonne turn their backs to the audience and walk toward the threshold together—the resonance of the chant and the rhythmic click of high heels moving in tune. The sacred and the contemporary body share the same departing line, and then the space is released.

Running through this terrain, Isu Mignon Mignonne performs a drag that is associated with Cha's twelve masks based on her previous forensic studies, hanging on the exhibition space. Cha has spoken of wanting the mask to possess the performer as in the *noh* tradition: not a face worn over a face, but a form that inhabits the body and makes it act according to its own will.¹² The drag here crosses gender not to arrive at another fixed position but to sustain the crossing itself—a dissonant drag that receives the abjection of bodies and gender. This possession is sonically manifest as Isu counts to 365, marking the days of a year. Each number is uttered with shifting rhythms and fractured voices, as if with each count she wears a different mask. Through this vocal metamorphosis, the linear progression of time is shattered into a series of heterogeneous affects, ensuring that the performer's presence is never singular, but always a shifting site of multiple, inhabiting spirits.

If the earlier hole marked the limit of representation, this final section approaches the limit of language itself. Words persist, but they no longer secure meaning. They circulate as fragments—residues of prior utterances, traces that cannot be fully reabsorbed. The performance does not restore coherence to these fragments. It holds them in suspension: not silence, but something closer to its edge, where words continue to appear yet no longer guarantee what they once held. From ash, a body with red hair rises. The dead come back. Nine lives. Life persists.

9. Ibid.

10. Ibid.

11. Sylvia Plath, *Lady Lazarus*, in *The Collected Poems*, ed. Ted Hughes (London: Faber and Faber, 1989).

12. Cha Yeonsà explained, excerpted from the conversation between the artist, April 26, 2026.

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Her curatorial project *Tongue of Rain* at Art Sonje Center (2024) was inspired by the layered dialogues of feminist poets Cecilia Vicuña, Theresa Hak Kyung Cha, and Kim Eon Hee. At Frieze Seoul 2024, she curated *Nerve or Divine Pathway*, a performance program that sought to create a ritual space, challenging contemporary language politics. As the former Deputy Director at Art Sonje Center, she has held curatorial positions at Nam June Paik Art Center, the Korean Cultural Centre UK, and the Liverpool Biennial.